

1450–1624

SYMBOLISM AND FANTASY

The Renaissance world revolved around emblems, iconography, and allegories, and people delighted in using these symbolic representations in dress. Almost any animal, plant, god, object, colour, or foreign fashion could be used metaphorically to say something more than itself. At a time when most people could not read, visual meanings were especially important. Medieval heraldry had established symbols as distinctive badges of houses and families. Personal iconography became a poetic, decorative language using emblems such as knots, phoenixes, carnations, and lilies to show a person's virtues along with other abstract ideas. These could be embroidered or painted on to clothing, or worked into jewellery or armour. Characters from religion and classical mythology were popular allegorical themes, often used to convey hidden moral or political messages. At masques (theatrical court entertainments) and costume balls fancy dress was an opportunity to draw on different cultures.

RED AND BLACK



Colour itself was a symbol with complex meanings. The most prized shades were true black and crimson or scarlet. Red denoted power and was used by royalty, nobility, and religious authorities, such as the pope and his cardinals above.

Following 16th-century religious divisions, members of both the Catholic and Protestant churches used black to show their piety, humility, and restraint. But dyeing cloth a deep, rich black was expensive in terms of time and ingredients, so the colour was also a fashionable way to show off wealth alongside spiritual values.

Small mask as token disguise
Courtesan showing off beautiful clothes



Venetian carnival Masquerade balls were a chance to throw off social convention and change roles through disguises. The Italian comedy theatre *commedia dell'arte* introduced stock characters like Harlequin and Pantalone as popular costumes.

Pose like a classical statue
Loose, "uncivilized" hair

Fanciful floral tattoos

Skin looks like embroidery

Orientalist hat

Sculpted leather mask

Harlequin costume with fleur-de-lis and templar crosses

Exotic tunic and tassels

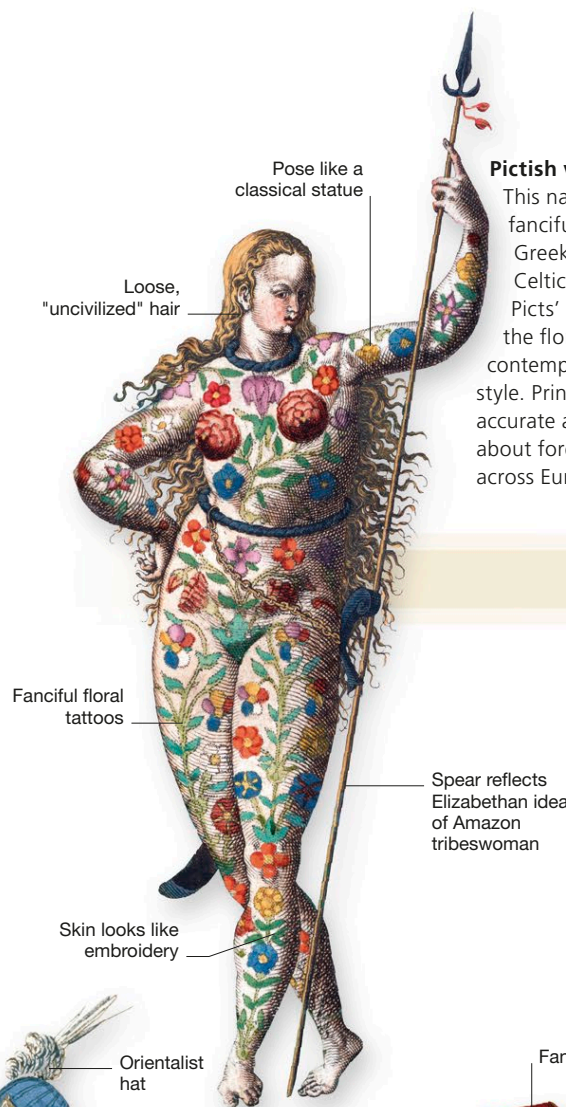
Bright colours and symbols, probably printed

Overskirt made of fine linen panes held together with buttons

Sword signifies Catherine's martyrdom

Pictish warrior woman

This naked woman is a fanciful take on classical Greek mythology and Celtic folklore. Tales of the Picts' painted skins inspired the floral tattooing in the contemporary Elizabethan style. Prints spread a mix of accurate and imaginary ideas about foreign or past cultures across Europe.



Spear reflects Elizabethan idea of Amazon tribeswoman

Fantasy headress

Puffed sleeves did not exist in normal dress



Holy fantasy dress Artists used inventive imaginary dress in their pictures of female saints, like this c.1500 Flemish depiction of Saint Catherine. Oriental elements such as drapery and tassels helped conjure an out-of-this world biblical setting.